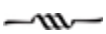
newspapers daily. A motorbike rider came and took the guy on pillion and sped away.

Shortly, the bikers reached a residential neighbourhood in the northern part of Madras —Kodungaiyur—and stopped in front of a house. A man opened the door and led them in. The bikers wanted to speak to someone.

‘We have found a suitable spot where we can plant the device,’ said one of the bikers.

‘Good. We can treat SIT in the same way as we did Rajiv Gandhi,’ spoke the man who was seen in Haribabu’s photograph wearing a white kurta pyjama. While the SIT had just begun to sense a breakthrough in its investigation, an assassin was plotting to blow up its very office.



A superintendent in the Madras IB, Mani Shankar, intercepted a communication between a ‘rogue station’ somewhere within his city and another that he suspected to be in Jaffna. The communication was in alphanumeric codes. In the aftermath of Rajiv Gandhi’s assassination, the IB was on high alert. He immediately got a colleague to crack the coded message. It said: ‘Ready to strike in Malligai. Send boat for immediate return.’ The intelligence officer understood it had to do with the LTTE. He immediately sent it marked ‘Top Secret’ to the SIT’s office in Malligai.

Mani Shankar’s colleague was Anirudhya’s IB contact in Madras. After careful thought, he shared this intelligence with Anirudhya—the LTTE was planning to strike at the SIT. While it had been Anirudhya’s dream to work for *India Today*, he missed his daily reporting job at the *Times*. This kind of explosive information would probably become stale by the time his story was published.

He called Badhwar and shared the message the IB had intercepted. Badhwar sounded happy to note that his new recruit was ‘getting the hard news’. He encouraged Anirudhya with a ‘keep it up’ and hung up. For a reporter who had been groomed in ‘daily’ culture, this was a ‘front-page exclusive’. But for the managing editor of one of India’s most famous